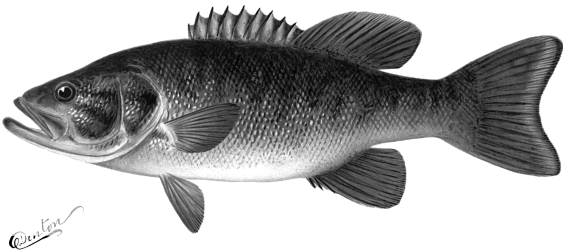


Smallmouth Bass

Micropterus dolomieu

Rock, gravel and hard bottom — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Season

Time of day

Bronze rather than green, with dark *vertical* bars instead of one horizontal stripe, and a red or orange eye. The upper jaw stops under the eye. The dorsal fin is one continuous fin, not pinched.

12–17 in typical; 18 in and up is a strong fish. State record 9 lb 1 oz. Pound for pound the hardest-fighting fish in either lake.

Gravel and rubble in 3–10 ft at 60–65 °F, a little later and deeper than largemouth. Pine Lake’s 90% gravel bottom is close to ideal smallmouth habitat.

Crayfish above all, then minnows, perch fry and insect larvae. Match the crayfish and you are most of the way there.

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Dawn		Mid		Dusk		Night					

Where

- Pine

North

Structure

Season
- This is a smallmouth lake. Spots **2** (north-east breaks), **3** (east wall), **4** (the mid-lake bar) and **8**. The bar is the best smallmouth spot in the county on a good October morning.

Spots **3** and **4**. The south-end shoal complex is the equivalent of Pine’s bar.

Hard bottom with a fast change in depth. Rock points, gravel bars, rip-rap, boulder fields. If your jig comes back scuffed, you are in the right place.

Shallow and aggressive in May–June, deep and moody in July–August, then shallow and violent again in late September and October.

How

- Best all-round

Deep and finicky

Cold water

Live bait
- A tube jig dragged and hopped on the bottom. It looks exactly like a fleeing crayfish and nothing else is needed most days.

Drop-shot with a small minnow-shaped plastic, *see the **drop-shot sheet***. This is how you fish Pine Lake’s east wall in August.

A suspending jerkbait, worked with long pauses. In 45–55 °F water the pause is the whole presentation.

A live crayfish or a large leech on a plain hook with one split shot, *see the **split shot sheet***. Deadly and simple.

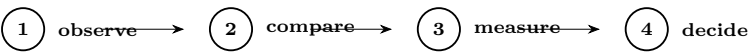
The one thing to remember

Smallmouth live where the bottom is hard. Largemouth live where the cover is soft. On the same lake, on the same day, that one distinction sorts almost every spot.

Worth knowing

Slower than you think	Smallmouth grow more slowly than largemouth in the same water. A 17 in smallmouth in southern Wisconsin is commonly eight to ten years old. There are not many of them and they do not replace quickly.
They hunt in groups	Unlike largemouth, smallmouth commonly patrol in loose packs of similar-sized fish. If you catch one on a bar, cast straight back — the school is usually still there, and the competition makes them bolder.
Crayfish, overwhelmingly	Stomach studies on rocky lakes routinely find crayfish as the dominant food by volume. Everything about a tube jig — the profile, the bottom contact, the puff of sediment — is an imitation of one fleeing backwards.
They fight above their weight	A smallmouth’s caudal peduncle — the muscle in front of the tail — is proportionally larger than a largemouth’s, and its habit of running to open water rather than into cover is why a two-pounder feels like four.
The nest is guarded hard	A male smallmouth will strike a lure dropped on his bed out of aggression, not hunger, and he will keep doing it. It is easy fishing and it costs the year class. Move off beds you can see.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	With the mouth closed, does the upper jaw stop beneath the eye, with a nearly continuous dorsal fin?
Rule out	Largemouth jaw extends beyond the eye and the dorsal is deeply pinched; body colour changes with water.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: press the closed snout to the board stop and read the longest tail tip.
Field proof	Jaw reach and dorsal shape must agree before counting it as smallmouth. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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